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Southeast Nuba social relations

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C. Cosmology: Death, Funeral and Death Commemoration

As the deceased's bed is brought out to the men's hut where the *nyerēnn* will be held, great wailing breaks out, particularly by women of the matrilineal section of the deceased and the patrilineal section of the deceased. This may also include old lovers (if the deceased is male), and always close female kin. Such women have to be restrained from throwing themselves on the bed, in the air, and from flipping and rolling on the ground. The conspicuous behavior is important, even though some of these women more distantly related to the deceased may later in the day be laughing and joking with friends.

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During the *nyerēnn*, guests will come to address the bed, women to break calabashes (sometimes with small amounts of oil in them as special respect) over the bedposts, men to challenge and utter whooping noises, and sometimes prance as if having heard their praises sung or in challenge. Men will also stroke the bed with bits of grass as they whoop and challenge, uttering praises and challenges concerning the deceased, such as the stroking of persons in a *paratōrga* ceremony at which persons are stroked or touched on the shoulders in blessing them. More rarely, men will fire off a weapon at these times (this is probably not common simply because of the attendance of outsiders who might report the Southeast Nuba with weapons, illegal in Southern Kordofan since the civil war), and women may flip in the air after breaking their calabash(es). The challenges are uttered in general, and not toward onlookers, who are seated in patrilineal section group surrounding the men's hut - with more distant patrilineal sections at greater distances. During the heat of the funeral *nyerēnn* (when elder men may be prancing, women flipping), the bed of the deceased may be fanned by women (of the

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patrician section linked to that of the deceased) with batches of feathers to 'cool' it. Adult women will also dance in the *nyertūnn* dance fashion¹³ and, if an ex-wife or an old lover or simply so inclined, she will, on the appropriate drum cadence, throw her leg on one of the bed posts for a few seconds - as she might have done years earlier in a men's hut to a young *kadūdōr* to invite a rendezvous.

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A funeral *nyerēnn* may last for two hours or more, and involve at least three drummers, and if the funeral of an adult male, two or three singers as well. At the funerals of women and children, praises are not sung at the *nyerēnn* (except if the woman was a *kabaja* in which case her matriclan section praises will be sung) - though later in the day *kāmā* choruses may perform if engaged by kin of the deceased, whether or not the deceased is a woman or a child. And the first day's ceremonies are broken up by various rituals, such as when the principal funeral animal (say, a large bull for an important deceased) is brought to the bed, its head touched to each corner, then dusted with ■ 298 mushroom, chalk, or burned grass (depending on which is appropriate to the deceased's patrician section) prior to being led off a short distance for the sacrifice (which takes place with the spear of the deceased). If the animal is particularly fine, the deceased's belt (or *kamjan*) may be hung around its neck prior to its sacrifice. A fire is built, and the animal is butchered and most portions immediately roasted for guests. After this ritual and after most others have paid their respects (indeed, these may wait until the *nyerēnn* is actually finished), one of the funeral directors and his assistants (from the patrician sections linked to that of the deceased)¹⁴ begins the planting ritual which accompanies the funeral of all adult males. A hoe from the bed of the deceased is symbolically sharpened, and both slow-ripening yellow grain and sesame are 'planted' all the way around the bed. It is then 'weeded', grain broadcast, additionally planted, then symbolically harvested with the deceased's knife. Then the container which held the grain is broken on the bed post (the entire area is now littered with broken calabashes). In a ritual designed to symbolize abundance of beer (informants stressed that all this was for insurance to the living, not for beer or grain in the afterlife, indeed, until I asked the question, it has not occurred to them that it could be for the afterlife), six women (again of the linked patrician sections to that of the deceased) then crawl around the bed, passing a pot from head of each of them to the head of the person behind them. The planting ritual is abbreviated somewhat for a deceased female or sometimes not held. For a deceased female, there is also the ubiquitous fertility ritual (see [Cross-Reference: \(Figure 17\)](#)). This ritual, involving attending women of the patrician section and administered by women of the *kōrōgana* clan section to that of the deceased, is a simple ritual to insure successful pregnancy. It involves, as may be seen in [Cross-Reference: \(Figure 17\)](#), a short invocation, then passing a strip of grass around the abdomen of each adult woman in attendance, whether or not she still be of child-bearing age. It is of significance to our reading that the ubiquitous rituals for women deceased involve insurance of reproduction, whereas the common rituals to all male deceased involve planting production. The constitution of men and of women as producers and reproducers, respectively, is clear.

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13. It is to be remembered that here, as all ritual occasions, only elders (women well along in childbearing years or beyond, men of *kadōnnga* age grade) participate. For women it is one of the few times they dance the *nyertūnn* they were so active in while still

unmarried. The common praise - song/dance (*nyertūnn*) of young men and young women (at which elder men may occasionally prance on hearing their praises or those of their younger patrikin) is lexically discriminated from the praise-song (and sometimes dance) (*nyerēnn*), involving elders only (at which non-elders never prance nor dance) at funerals. Both terms derive from the stem *nyer* - ("to sing").

14. Funeral directors and assistants (male and female) are elders chosen for each patrician section to serve until retirement by elders of the clan section. The actual director will come from a first *daba* linked clan to that of the deceased, and his/her assistants will be from the second *daba* (see [Cross-Reference: \(Table 28\)](#), and) linked clan to that of the deceased. A person may be the director *vis-à-vis* one patrician section, but the assistant to the director at another. As noted below, directors and assistants are compensated in portion of the sacrifice.

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